NITISH PLAYS UNIFIER

The Bihar chief minister has set himself the task of aligning opposition parties against the BJP for the 2024 general election. Not only does it mean bringing diverse regional forces together, but also getting the Congress to scale down its ambitions wherever needed

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA



ASK NITISH KUMAR, THE CHIEF MINISTER OF BIHAR AND JANATA DAL (UNITED) SUPREMO, how much sugar he wants in his cup of tea, and he will likely tell you, just a quarter spoon, not a pinch more. Any more, he thinks, will ruin his cuppa. That same attention to detail and the willingness to achieve a perfect balance could perhaps come in handy as, a year ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election, he sets out to fix a different, much bigger, boiling pot: of an implosive, perpetually sizzling national opposition.

On April 12, Nitish, accompanied by his deputy CM and Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav, was in New Delhi for a closed-door meeting with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi. Their goal: to forge the "broadest possible" opposition unity in the run-up to the general election in order to oust the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

That's a mammoth task considering not all parties are on the same page. The work, thus, has been divided. While Kharge, having already started with his outreach to Uddhav Thackeray of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) and Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, will try to bring like-minded parties together, Nitish has been entrusted with much of the heavy-lifting—bringing on board parties that are not comfortable joining hands with the Congress.

Nitish's key goal is to engage four prominent players. While Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bengal, Arvind Kejriwal's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Delhi and Punjab and K. Chandrasekhar Rao's Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) in Telangana are the ruling parties in their respective states, former Uttar Pradesh chief minister and Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav is a formidable opposition force in Uttar Pradesh. Together, these five states account for 159 of the Lok Sabha seats—nearly 30 per cent of the 543 seats in the lower house. As of now, the BJP occupies 94 of them—nearly 60 per cent.

Nitish and several other opposition leaders understand that the BJP's success in these states was on account of the division of anti-BJP votes. The idea, thus, is to make the Congress recognise the combined strength of regional leaders in these five states. In doing so, what Nitish also has to achieve—and that is perhaps the more difficult task—is the Congress's commitment to be more than just 'conventionally accommodative'. Simultaneously, he has to convince leaders who see the Congress as a rival in their respective states. Like Yadav and Mamata, who have already hinted that they won't align with the grand old party in the upcoming election.

The obstacles apart, the timing of Nitish's outreach seems just right. With Rahul Gandhi's disqualification from the Lok Sabha last month, the Congress as well as other opposition leaders have been shaken out of their 'ego-chambers'. "While the Congress has become fully aware that any further dilly-dallying on the issue of opposition unity can erase their footprint even further, opposition leaders too are seeing a similar risk. No wonder, every major voice in the opposition condemned Rahul's disqualification," says a JD(U) source.